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If we look at Franz Kafka's writings from the perspective of political theory, it seems, as with Benjamin, that the politics he offers us, if any, are those of passivity, failure, and doom. We have noted several times Kafka's quip to Brod that there is "plenty of hope, an infinite amount of hope—but not for us."¹ This seems like a grim joke, a typically "Kafkaesque" commentary on the futility of resistance, on the inevitability of defeat. At the end of *The Trial*, K., the central character, who seems to epitomize the hapless, anxious characters that people a Kafka novel or story, is stabbed in the heart by his tormentors and dies, in his own words, "Like a dog!" ("Wie ein hund!"),² suggesting the fate of all of us, in the face of obscure and irresistible powers. Many scholars of Kafka have described his supposed Zionism or the way he uses psychological or other kinds of symbolism to denote states of despair and the tyrannies of power, but it is not clear that any of this amounts to a political theory or a model for some kind of political resistance.³

Yet when we read Kafka the way Walter Benjamin read him, a very different thinker emerges. To his credit, Benjamin never tries to unlock the secrets of Kafka's text, as so many other commentators have. Instead, I argue, Benjamin seeks to reread Kafka as a fellow conspirator, endowing him with the same sort of conspiratorial strategies that Benjamin espouses in his own work. Conspiracy is required for Kafka because he is as suspicious—if not more so—of human intentionality as Benjamin himself.

In earlier chapters we have already encountered a paradox that arises from a politics based on distrusting our own intentions. If we are not let in on this secret, if the hope it offers is "not for us," what use is it to us? Most importantly, from the position of political theory, what kind of politics, what sort of relationality, stems from a conspiracy that seems to deny what we have come to regard as the very basis of political life? In this chapter, I will argue that Benjamin finds in Kafka a potential answer to these

questions. In Kafka, he discovers a way for human beings to act politically without simply reproducing the mythologies that both writers oppose; Benjamin finds a way to do an end run around our own compromised intentionality, without giving up on the possibility of political resistance, or even the possibility of a “progressive deepening of . . . intention.”

Key to Benjamin’s insight is the role of misrecognition in Kafka’s texts. Kafka shows that, given our compromised status, given the failures of our intentionality, we will always misread and misrecognize the signs of order, community, and authority that compose our world. Rather than try to save his characters from their delusions, Kafka gives them over to them, but in such a way as to subvert and distort their object. Kafka’s characters desperately try to conform to the various powers that they see as organizing their life, but they fail, usually miserably, in their attempt. As we have already seen, such a failure can, in Benjamin’s conspiratorial light, be turned into an asset; it becomes a failure to read a faux mythology “correctly,” a failure to make sense of a symbolic universe that they seem to have no choice but to submit to.⁴

In addition to this failure, this stubborn and providential misrecognition, Kafka supplies Benjamin with another, crucial element: a particular, and textual, form of messianism that subverts the central powers (of both the political and divine varieties) that unite and control his characters. As we will see further, particularly in *The Castle*, Kafka offers us a parable for what Benjamin calls “divine violence”: a messiah that voids or destroys its own symbols of power, its own mythologies.⁵ Such a self-voiding of the messiah disrupts the central narratives of authority, leaving the communities that are organized in the name of its worship in the strange position of becoming reluctant, or perhaps even unknowing, conspirators against that which they most urgently seek to join up and collude with.

The combination of our own failure to read the mythologies of the world correctly and the self-voiding of a messiah who makes such a misreading possible in the first place amounts to a politics of “recognizing misrecognition” wherein signs are neither worshipped as true nor abandoned altogether. From Kafka’s perspective—one that Benjamin takes much from—our misrecognition need not be the basis for the ongoing practice of political idolatry. Instead, by remaining attuned to the *aporias* and lapses in our own narratives of power and authority, we can benefit from those (relatively) unscripted spaces that appear whenever those narratives are disrupted (in part by our own acts of misrecognition). The “agency” that such disruptions produce is not so much our own (at least as we are currently constituted) as it is the result of our conspiracy; it is

composed of the remnants of our fetishistic sense of self and community when those sites have been destabilized and decentered, the basis for a “not us” who may have some basis for hope after all.

The value of reading Kafka and Benjamin in “constellation” with one another is to get a better sense of the role that conspiracy can play in politics. When we read Kafka through a conspiratorial (and Benjaminian) lens, we find a sense of how communities are formed, lives are lived, apart from (even as they are intimately entangled with) the great narratives of state and divine power that seem to underlie them. As already noted, when those great narratives are disrupted, these communities are not erased. Instead they emerge more clearly as having narratives of their own, narratives that are otherwise eclipsed by the notions of state and divine power they purportedly serve.

Kafka's Secrets

Given his reading of Kafka, and given his own interest in secrecy and conspiracies, as well as his own suspicion of human intentions, Benjamin does not seek to unlock Kafka's secrets. Indeed, he characterizes those secrets in such a way that unlocking them does not really seem possible; in keeping with their shared interest in Jewish mysticism, the notion of an immanent and unfathomable doctrine that can be gestured at but not described or even remotely understood is central to both writers.⁶ Benjamin tells us “Kafka could understand things only in the form of a *gestus*, and this *gestus* which he did not understand constitutes the cloudy part of the parables.”⁷ It is telling that for Benjamin even Kafka did not understand the nature of the gestures he describes: here, the author surrenders his traditional sovereignty over his characters and their actions.⁸

In thinking about Kafka as Benjamin's coconspirator, we see a crucial development between his two best-known writings on Kafka. The first, “Franz Kafka: On the Tenth Anniversary of His Death,” was written in 1934. The short fragment “Some Reflections on Kafka” was written in a letter to Gershom Scholem four years later. Under ordinary circumstances four years is not a long period of time, but between 1934 and 1938 Benjamin's life, and the world around him, was changing radically. The second writing, however short, makes an explicit break with his first reading when he says, “my main criticism of that [earlier] study today is its apologetic character” and goes on to write:

To do justice to the figure of Kafka in its purity and its peculiar beauty one must never lose sight of one thing: it is the purity and beauty of a failure. The circumstances of this failure are manifold. One is tempted to say: once he was certain of eventual failure, everything worked out for him *en route* as in a dream. There is nothing more memorable than the fervor with which Kafka emphasized his failure.⁹

To focus on Kafka as a failure is very much in keeping with Benjamin's fascination with failure more generally, as we have already seen in his study of Baudelaire and all of the failed revolutionaries who lived, drank, and died in nineteenth-century France. As already noted, for Benjamin, particularly in his later years, failure was in fact essential in order to bypass or defeat compromised human intentions. The "successes" of this world subscribe to the dominant ideology of history, time, order, and progress. To be out of time is to be a "failure" and, therefore, to fail to acquiesce to the hegemony of global capital whether in its fascist or liberal guises.

Benjamin's first essay on Kafka is hardly sunny or optimistic, and yet it is characterized by a certain version of redemptive possibility—one that he will retreat from in his later essay. This is especially evident when he writes in the earlier essay about Kafka's book *Amerika* (aka *The Man Who Disappeared*).¹⁰ In his reading of that book, Benjamin focuses on the end of the novel, which describes the so-called Theater of Oklahoma. Benjamin tells us, "all that is expected of the applicants [to the Theater] is the ability to play themselves. It is no longer within the realm of possibility that they could, if necessary, be what they claim to be."¹¹ This seems to be a kind of triumph of self over intention. What "they claim to be" could mean these characters' conscious, deeply compromised intentionality. The idea of being able "play [oneself]" seems to afford us the possibility of avoiding our own egos without falling into a naturalizing positivism (where we would just "be ourselves"). This passage is reminiscent of Benjamin's writings in "The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction" (written two years later, in 1936), where Benjamin lauds Soviet films in which "some of the players . . . are not actors in our sense but people who portray *themselves*."¹² This idea of a redemptive possibility for identity, whether it is produced in film (as in the Soviet Union) or by the doubly removed status of characters in a play (staged by the Theater of Oklahoma) that lies within a novel (*Amerika*), offers itself as an initial answer to the problem of intentionality.

Even in that first essay, however, Benjamin anticipates the darker view of Kafka he will espouse in 1938 (thus once again performing a kind of constellation with himself). He writes:

[Kafka's testament,] which no one interested in Kafka can disregard, says that the writings did not satisfy their author, that he regarded his efforts as failures, that he counted himself among those who were bound to failure. He did fail in his grandiose attempt to convert poetry into doctrine, to turn it into a parable and restore to it that stability and unpretentiousness which, in the face of reason, seemed to him to be the only appropriate thing for it. No other writer has obeyed the commandment "Thou shalt not make unto thee a graven image" so faithfully.¹³

It is the last sentence of this passage especially that gives us a clue to what Benjamin is trying to work out. It suggests that Kafka was able to follow the second commandment *only* because he failed at representation. In other words, for Benjamin, the only way to avoid idolatry is to blatantly and legibly fail in one's attempt to produce an idol—even the idol of one's own self (that is, of "being oneself"). Our failure or misrecognition is all that saves us from our own implication in and compromise with the phantasmagoria, and the more clearly we fail, the better.

In the comparison between the two passages from Benjamin's 1934 and 1938 essays on Kafka, we can see another stark contrast that may help to further illuminate this developing relationship between failure and representation. On the one hand, in "Franz Kafka," Benjamin tells us that Kafka's prose pieces "have . . . a similar relationship to doctrine as the Haggadah [the representation of the divine law] does to the Halakah [the divine law itself]."¹⁴ In other words, Kafka's texts serve divine truth in the same way the representation of God's law (Haggadah) reflects the law itself (Halakah). Yet in 1938 (in a passage already cited in the introduction) he writes to Scholem that Kafka's parables "do not modestly lie at the feet of the doctrine, as the Haggadah lies at the feet of the Halakah. Though apparently reduced to submission, they unexpectedly raise a mighty paw against it."¹⁵ Here we see a much darker and more conspiratorial view on Benjamin's part (and by extension on Kafka's as well). As World War II and the Holocaust come down over his head, Benjamin comes to appreciate ever more the virtues of failure, now recast as a form of subversion, even in a sense the subversion of Halakah. As we have already noted, the purpose of this subversion is not so much directed against God per se but

against our (false) anticipation of God and law. He also tells us that Kafka “sacrificed truth for the sake of clinging to its transmissibility, its haggadic element.”¹⁶ In light of this, we might say that this “mighty paw” raised against Halakah is a gesture against idolatry; it is to favor transmissibility, the materiality of Haggadah, over the kinds of truth that are promised but never delivered.

As we have already seen in the previous chapter when looking at Benjamin’s treatment of the figure of Satan, we must in effect betray God to preserve God as an *aporia*, an interruption of our own mythological narratives. Here again, the “failure” of representation, the conspiratorial use of Haggadah against Law, becomes a way to preserve Law in its own “purity” and “beauty,” allowing for hope (“an infinite amount of hope—but not for us”).

Whereas when left to its own devices, Haggadah “modestly lie[s] at the feet of the doctrine,” when it is engaged with conspiratorially, Haggadah becomes, as we will see more clearly, a weapon of misrecognition, a “mighty paw” raised against the false manifestations of Halakah. This gesture “against” God, Law, and fate is in fact the epitome of what I am calling Kafka’s and Benjamin’s shared conspiratorial style. In Kafka’s case this conspiracy takes the explicit (but unfathomable) form of the parable.

Kafkaesque Parables

In his discussion of Kafka’s use of parables, Benjamin tells us that Kafka “took all conceivable precautions against the interpretation of his writings.”¹⁷ He also tells us that ordinarily with parables “it is the reader’s pleasure to smooth [the parable] out so that he has the meaning on the palm of his hand. Kafka’s parables, however, unfold in . . . the way a bud turns into a blossom.”¹⁸ Thus in terms of their legibility, for Benjamin Kafka’s parables are beautiful, and possibly familiar but not necessarily illuminating.

In his own treatment of parables, Kafka openly espouses his desire to be cryptic. In his short, fragmentary (or at least just short) essay “On Parables,” he tells us that “all these parables really set out to say merely that the incomprehensible is incomprehensible, and we know that already. But the cares we have to struggle with every day: that is a different matter.”¹⁹ Yet Kafka does not leave it quite at that, because as we have already seen, representation and Halakah are in a relationship for him, even if it is at times a necessarily confrontational one. Thus he goes on to write:

Concerning this a man once said: Why such reluctance? If you only followed the parables you yourselves would become parables and with that rid of all your daily cares.

Another said: I bet that is also a parable.

The first said: You have won.

The second said: But unfortunately only in parable.

The first said: No, in reality: in parable you have lost.²⁰

This is of course “a parable,” indeed it is a “parable about parables” (reminiscent of de Man’s “metafigure,” which means to “[write] figuratively about figures”).²¹ In this case, the parable addresses the very question of how parables are related to daily life, that is to say (at least in the emphasis I am focusing on here) on the question of politics, the ordering of our lives. Kafka tends to punish those who would painfully work out his logic by deliberately withholding that logic in the first place. It is perhaps more profitable to focus, as Benjamin suggests, on the gesture that his parable makes. Taken in this spirit, we might say that this fragment suggests that, although it is futile to attempt to understand Kafka’s parables, to make the attempt nonetheless is to be “rid of all your daily cares.” Our struggle with a parable, it seems, is meant to be lost, but the encounter with it is still meant to allow us to “win” in our daily life; we are not left unaffected by our brush with it even though it offers us nothing at all.

Such an interpretation of parables may be even more clear in what is perhaps the most paradigmatic moment of parable reading that Kafka executes, namely the scene toward the very end of *The Trial* where K. encounters a priest who seeks to interpret (along with K.) the parable “Before the Law.” This encounter with the priest comes when K. is increasingly desperate. His “case is going badly,” as the priest informs him (but K. already knows this).²²

The parable of “Before the Law” is so well known that I will only briefly paraphrase it here: a man from the country comes before a doorway to the law, and the doorkeeper there bars his entry. The man asks if he can get in later and the doorkeeper says “That’s possible,”²³ and so the man waits, on a stool the doorkeeper provides him with, for his whole life, year after year, never being let in. At the end, as he is dying, the doorkeeper bends over the man to hear his last question:

“Everyone wants access to the law,” says the man, “how come, over all these years, no one but me has asked to be let in?” The door-

keeper . . . shouts to him: "Nobody else could have got in this way, as this entrance was meant only for you. Now I'll go and close it."²⁴

As parables are wont to do, this parable forces us to examine it closely, to try to discern the meaning. As if not content to trust in his own inscrutability, in *The Trial* Kafka has K. and the priest themselves unsuccessfully try to discern the meaning of "Before the Law." This is one of those rare and wonderful metatextual moments when two characters in a story attempt to work out what we, the readers are meant to work out (or not work out, as the case may be) for ourselves; by this device the normal lines between author and reader become blurred; we become implicated all the more in the process of interpretation even as Kafka directly interferes with that process.

In their discussions of the parable, K. and the priest agree on nothing. Suffering from arbitrary justice, K. empathizes with the man from the country. He sees how justice is wrong, arrogant, and indeed arbitrary. The priest, who works for the state (he claims to be a prison chaplain), takes the side of the doorkeeper, offering legalistic arguments for why he is right. In the hands of many an author matters might have been left there; we come to the determination that a parable is always interpreted from our own position.

Yet Kafka pushes this further; as is often the case in his work, an alternative way to read this parable comes closer to the middle than the end of this discourse. K. tries to pin the priest down by saying, "So you think the man was not cheated, do you?" and the priest answers:

Don't get me wrong . . . I'm just pointing out the different opinions about it. You shouldn't pay too much attention to people's opinions. The text cannot be altered, and the various opinions are often no more than an expression of despair over it.²⁵

Here, we see that "the text cannot be altered." In other words, we are not permitted to understand the text but that doesn't mean that the text has no effect on us; it has a form, a material presence that we continually return to. The parable thus preserves the inscrutability of parables; it insists on (and therefore gives evidence of) its secret and just as sternly lets us know that we will never come to know it.²⁶

Even in the face of such an absolute denial, we see that we are not left unaffected by such a gesture. We are affected not so much by the "truth" of

the parable, since that is unknown to us, but by the way we organize—and live—our lives in the face of the parable. The “daily cares” and the “truth of the parable” are thus not total strangers; in the face of the parable, our acts of interpretation, however random and arbitrary they might be, serve as a kind of anchor through which we form connections with one another, determining how we see ourselves in relation to others, for better or for worse.

In this way we begin to see the relevance of Kafka for political theory (and, by extension, for Benjamin’s conspiracy as well). Whether the doorkeeper is above or below the man from the country (both positions are argued), whether the priest is a stern representative of the state or an ally of K., the parable serves as a point of contact, a mode of organizing that then produces relationships based on our own responses. In this way the act of interpretation becomes profoundly, and importantly, political.

We see the effects of this interpretation in the kinds of intimacies and relationships formed in the face of law and all the horrors and small mercies that are enacted in its name. In *The Trial*, we see in the strange banality of the court’s rooms, mixed up with ordinary people doing their wash and cooking cabbages, the intense jealousies produced between K., his lawyer, and other, equally hapless clients, the question of the various women that alternately intercede in K.’s situation and leave him to his fate. These relationships are all produced not despite but because of the mystery that Kafka sternly guards (not unlike the doorkeeper and with a similar kind of strange intimacy).

It is at this point that it is particularly helpful to read Kafka through the lens of Benjaminian interpretation. Kafka’s gesture serves here to render parables legible qua parables, even while rendering them illegible as a font of meaning or authority. He (or rather his text) thus indeed “raises a mighty paw” against Halakah by confounding it with its symbolic representations (Haggadah). Such a move reveals our understanding of Halakah to be merely text, obscure and tantalizing at the same time; Kafka subverts the notion that there is some “hidden truth” that lies within or beneath his parables. At the same time, by stripping away their content (or rather, by making it clear that the content is unavailable to us) Kafka shows how the parable serves to organize and form our responses, our lives, nonetheless. This exposure of a parable’s effectiveness even without having any authoritative meaning renders visible a process that is otherwise obscured by content, by our desire to “know what the text means.” This shows us that we can and do come together in ways that are not nec-

essarily organized by clear and authoritative meanings. While we are busy seeking “the truth” and meaning, we are in fact already engaged in a kind of community, one that is produced out of our own conspiratorial and interpretive acts. It is this unrecognized (or more accurately, as we will see further, misrecognized) subterranean community that forms the heart of Kafka’s politics.

Unfolding the Parable: *The Castle*

The same dynamics that we see in *The Trial* are also clearly visible in what might be considered Kafka’s magnum opus, *The Castle*.²⁷ Here, in the last book that Kafka wrote (and which he died without finishing), we also see how parables organize our lives without recourse to definitive and authoritative meanings. At the same time we see far more clearly the subterranean rumors, the conspiratorial resistances that amass even in the face of Halakah. In *The Castle*, for all the passivity that its narrator (also named K.) seems to display, we see the processes of conspiracy on the part of the author, the characters, and the readers alike.

Just as crucially, *The Castle* also illustrates the particular and unique form of messianism that is a necessary complement to the conspiracies of its characters. As we will see further, the fact that Kafka’s messiah is never recognized—or even consciously noticed as such—is essential to the form of redemption that it brings to the community it visits. Were it to be recognized, this messiah would instantly become merely another instantiation of dogma, of myth posing as divine truth. Kafka’s stealth messiah preserves our misrecognition and in this way allows us to continue to fail in bold and spectacular ways in our attempt to convey and understand Halakah. This failure permits us to succeed in our conspiracy against the mythologies that pass for Halakah in our world, a conspiracy that we are not necessarily conscious or desirous of but which is in fact what redeems us (if anything does) at the end of the day.

The Castle is a sprawling, loosely connected, and incomplete narrative, but one thing that unites it quite clearly is its strong attention to questions of representation. As is fairly well known, the book begins when the narrator, K., comes to a village dominated by a castle.²⁸ When K. first sees the castle, we are told it belongs to “Count Westwest,” but that turns out to be the only concrete reference to the castle’s chief occupant for the entire novel. The very strangeness of the name “Count Westwest” (the name is

the same in German, “Herrn Grafen Westwest”)²⁹ tends to draw attention to it as only a cipher, a stand-in for the central mystery of the novel.³⁰

The denizens of the village live in the shadow of the castle both literally and metaphorically. The entirety of their lives is spent in anticipation of the wishes and whims of the Castle. There is an intense hierarchy that emanates from the Castle, forming levels within levels. There are peasants, ordinary villagers, messengers such as Barnabas (who delivers K. his first so-called message from the Castle), and then the Castle officials themselves. One of these officials in particular, a man named Klammm, is the focus of much of the book’s intrigue.

Kafka’s treatment of Klammm and the effect of Klammm’s presence (or even absence) speaks directly to the way representation is treated in *The Castle*. He is first encountered as a mere scrawl, a signature on a letter sent to K. informing him of his service (a letter that K. reverently hangs on his wall). Thus Klammm (whose name in German as in English is redolent of silence and secrecy) is introduced as a kind of failed or obscure sign.³¹ K. is told that Klammm’s letter “is valuable and even venerable because of Klammm’s signature, which appears to be genuine.”³² But he is also told by the local village chairman that the letter’s contents (which read like a fairly straightforward letter of acceptance) are unofficial, to which K. complains that “you interpret the letter so well that all that’s finally left is a signature on a blank sheet of paper.”³³ Such attention to legibility, signature, and its relationship to identity and meaning reinforces and makes visible the material nature of representation. Kafka here seems to be reminding us that representation, for all its mystery and power, is nothing more than lines on paper, images, sounds, and pictures.

Klammm serves as a cipher not just in name but also in his very person. As with Kafka’s treatment of the parable “Before the Law” in *The Trial*, the figure of Klammm gets taken to extremes in an attempt to evade any clear “meaning” or purpose. The novel is structured as a series of revelations, usually from long conversations (and often with women who seem, in all of Kafka’s novels, to be slightly more alert to whatever passes for reality than the men). As the revelations continue, what we find is that all that we have come to believe about Klammm may be wrong and in fact Klammm might not even exist. Well into the book Olga, who is the Barnabas’s sister, offers a long speech that simultaneously dispels and confuses much of what we have assumed to be true up to this point. She offers that “Barnabas doubt[s] that the official identified . . . as Klammm really is Klammm.”³⁴ She goes on to say that

his appearance is of course well known in the village, some have actually seen him, everyone has heard of him, and what emerges from this mixture of sightings, rumors, and distorting ulterior motives is a picture of Klammm that is probably correct in its essential features. But only in its essential features. Otherwise it is variable and perhaps not even as variable as Klammm's real appearance. They say he looks completely different when he comes into the village and different when he leaves it, different before he has had a beer, different afterwards. . . . and, quite understandably after all this, almost utterly different up there at the Castle. . . . Now all these discrepancies did not of course come about by magic but are quite understandable, they are the product of the momentary mood, the degree of excitement, the countless gradations of hope or despair in which the observer . . . happens to find himself.³⁵

Klammm is only sighted, or thought to be sighted, in glimpses. Barnabas "once saw Klammm through a carriage window, or thought he saw him."³⁶ But later, the man who was introduced to him as Klammm looked totally different. K. himself only sights Klammm—if that is really who he was—once, through a peephole.³⁷

The effect of this cumulative undermining of Klammm's existence is twofold. On the one hand, Kafka seems to be playfully but purposefully unraveling our automatic deference to certain authority structures. This unraveling includes the authority of an official like Klammm, as well as the authority of the author of the text, in this case Kafka himself (whom we otherwise generally defer to). Even before Olga's speech, but certainly by that point, we can see Kafka busily undermining these assumptions on our part. Yet, on the other hand, Kafka also seems to be highlighting the way that such authority systems (of both the political and authorial sorts) produce intense responses (at least in terms of what such systems seem to promise). The letter that K. hangs on his wall was probably not written by Klammm (that was probably not his illegible signature), and yet the letter is "venerable" nonetheless. We see how power and authority function, even (or perhaps especially) as an exposed *aporia*, how they affect and organize those who live under their spell.

In his playful undermining of assumptions, his false starts and red herrings, Kafka exposes the complicity of his characters and even our own complicity as his readers in terms of our collective desire for clear, author-

itative meanings. He is thus setting the grounds for a conspiracy, one that is set exactly against those authority symbols that the characters in this book (and perhaps the readers as well) are deeply implicated with.

The Erotics of Klamm

For all of his elusiveness, and even his possible nonexistence, Klamm has a powerful effect on those around him. The very suggestion of Klamm's presence excites and activates the villagers in myriad ways. K. himself gets caught up in the worship of Klamm insofar as he becomes engaged to Frieda, a woman that Klamm "summons" (assuming that the summoner really is Klamm). The minute Frieda tells K. that she is Klamm's mistress, he becomes much more interested in her, soon falling in love with her and in effect taking her away from Klamm.

As the novel progresses, the Klamm-inspired couplings and uncouplings gain speed and become almost impossible to keep track of. In every case, Klamm serves not as an actual person or agent but as a pure marker of desire.³⁸ The erotic charge all of these characters receive is not from the "gentlemen" of the Castle but rather from their cipher (if there is in fact any difference between these things). In all cases, whether with women or men, the desires of the officials are conveyed by letters, by messengers and intermediaries, in other words, by signs. Barnabas, for example, is filled with joy at the letter he delivers to K. It is, in fact, the first message he has been entrusted with (even if Klamm didn't write it or send it). The allure of such semiotic power is nearly irresistible to the villagers. Olga tells K., "we know that women cannot help loving officials when the officials approach them, and indeed even beforehand they're in love with the officials, no matter how strongly they attempt to deny it."³⁹ The letters and the states of excitement and meaningfulness they produce organize the reality of these villagers, even though this is a system without a center, an enormously complex phantasm that nonetheless compels our responses. Kafka's parable dispels the idea the humans are "naturally" social or interested in each other as a matter of course; every relationship, no matter how intimate or mundane, is produced in relationship to these signs and symbols of authority. Yet these signs are themselves very vulnerable, hollow, and unsubstantial. It may very well be that the Castle is empty, or that only its outer halls are occupied by people who themselves imagine that there are tremendously important personages lurking in the inner halls. The actual high Castle officials, so crucial for the lives of the characters of this book, are never seen except in the most hesitant and uncertain glimpses.

Missing the Messiah

With one crucial exception: In one of the most telling moments of the whole book, K. actually has an encounter with one of the high lords of the Castle but doesn't even realize it. Hoping that he'll get a sighting of Klammm, K. stands by a fancy sleigh (he assumes it must belong to Klammm) parked in the courtyard of the "Gentlemen's Inn."⁴⁰ He is invited into the sleigh to get some cognac by the coachman. While he is taking a long sip of cognac, "it became bright, the electric light came on, not only inside, on the stairs, in the passage, and in the corridor, but outside above the entrance."⁴¹ K. jumps out of the sleigh, very nervous at being caught, and a "young gentleman, extremely good-looking, pale and reddish, but quite grave" comes over. K. ponders:

Actually, the worst part was that the gentleman had surprised him and that there hadn't been enough time to hide from him and to wait undisturbed from Klammm, or rather, that he hadn't shown sufficient presence of mind to stay in the sleigh, close the door, and wait there on the fur blankets for Klammm.⁴²

The gentleman says, "Come with me," to which K. responds, "I am waiting here for someone." The gentleman repeats "Come." And K. repeats, "But then I'll miss the person I'm waiting for." The gentleman responds, "You'll miss him whether you wait or go." And K. responds again, "Then I would rather miss him as I wait."⁴³ After this exchange, the gentleman leaves. The courtyard is locked and the lights switched off; K. is left alone and once again in the dark.

In a book some say is about waiting for the messiah, the messiah comes and leaves and K. doesn't even notice. He is, in fact, so fixated on Klammm, a lowly and possibly nonexistent servant of the Castle, that when a true lord appears (and not just in glimpses but fully, tangibly), he is unable to register his presence as anything but a distraction.⁴⁴ It is not until the lord begins to leave "quite slowly, as though wanting to show K. that it was still in his power to call [him] back,"⁴⁵ that K. seems to have some regrets. Even so Kafka writes: "Perhaps he had that power, but it would have done him no good; to call the sleigh back would be to drive himself away."⁴⁶

We see in K.'s bedazzlement with Klammm shades of idolatry—an idolatry that runs rampant in *The Castle*. Here the symbol has supplanted what it stands for. Klammm, a cipher and a joke, has become more important than a high lord and gentleman. By fixating on Klammm, K. is left (lit-

erally) in the dark. At this point, we seem to have reached the dark heart of this novel, the end of hope (for us, anyway), a failure and a dead end.

Yet when read through Benjamin's lens, as coconspirators we can read K.'s actions in a different light. We can see what K. does as an example once again of what Benjamin refers to as "rais[ing] a mighty paw" against Hallelah. In this example, Haggadah (if we think of Klamm as symbol or cipher) is indeed the vehicle for this conspiracy; the cipher is used to deliver us from our expectation of redemption. Kafka here reveals his conspiratorial strategy: rather than deride the "false symbol" to embrace the true God, he uses that false symbol to void any possibility of the true deity, cleansing that site of any representational aspirations. K.'s fixation on Klamm ensures that K. will never find the meaning he is searching for, never be "saved" from his own semiotic failure.

But note that K. does not act alone. He has an ally, albeit one he barely notices, namely a true lord of the castle, we might say, a messiah. Now that the messiah has come and gone, K. experiences a kind of freedom. Having missed God confers onto K. certain strange benefits:

It seemed to K. as if they had broken off all contact with him, but as if he were freer than ever and could wait as long as he wanted here in this place where he was generally not allowed, and as if he had fought for this freedom for himself in a manner nobody else could have done and as if nobody could touch him or drive him away, or even speak to him, yet—and this conviction was at least equally strong—as if there were nothing more senseless, nothing more desperate, than this freedom, this waiting, this invulnerability.⁴⁷

The key thing to note here is that K. is *still waiting* at the end of this passage. Nothing has really changed (in keeping with the Jewish notion Benjamin conveys us to that the messiah "would only make a slight adjustment in [the world]").⁴⁸ This is not Simone Weil's "waiting for God" wherein the waiting itself is sanctified by what it waits for. K. now knows (at least on some level) that he is waiting for nothing and there is a modicum of peace—and despair—in that knowledge.⁴⁹

Here, we come to the center of Kafka's parable. Suitably, this messianic arrival—and subsequent abandonment—occurs not at the end of the book but tucked away in the middle. Just like the event it conveys, this section of the book comes and goes virtually unnoticed, but it also potentially transforms our reading of the text. This moment definitively undoes any hope for a final, perfect redemption, for some great resolution of meaning

wherein the parable tells us a profound truth. This is thus an ur-metatextual moment, when the text announces its own impossibility of self-resolution. We, the reader, are left, like K. in the dark, but perhaps now (also like K.) relatively freed of the need to understand or discover the parable's meaning (since such a meaning has been tantalizingly dangled before us, then removed once and for all). The structures, allures, and powers of text become more legible and perhaps available to us, but minus that great centralizing organizing principle, the sovereign voice of the author/messiah who promises us something certain as a reward for our striving to interpret.

In this way, the messianic figure in *The Castle* does what Kafka does as author throughout his texts; it forcefully intervenes in his narratives in order to demonstrate that all of the narrative structures we attribute to his agency are in fact without meaning. In the face of that meaninglessness, all of our allegiance and subservience to the symbols of power become, as it were, useless, leaving us in the position of being stooges and wannabes who have no choice now but to rebel against what they would otherwise seek to worship and obey. In this process the text, the set of signs and symbols by which we would come to "know the truth," has gone from being a tool that we strive to use in our desire for interpretation, to an ally that shows us the degree to which we are influenced and shaped by texts (even as its "meaning" is withheld from us). This is the epitome of textual conspiracy.

It might seem as if Kafka is suggesting that we can dispense with the divine and political constructions of authority altogether, that we might be able to form "sideways" communities (in this case, between K. and the villagers) unorganized, undominated, and free of any taint of representation in the face of such revelations. But Kafka is too complex, too tragic a thinker to offer such a ready solution. To think this would be to presume that the messiah really *had* freed us, even from itself, whereas Kafka's messiah, it is important to stress, does virtually nothing at all. In *The Castle* we are not so much liberated from the symbols and structures of authority as those symbols are displaced, decentered. This messiah is very much akin to the one that we found in Benjamin's treatment of Jesus as well; both authors portray messiahs whose "redemptive" features come from the way they void themselves (or are voided) as sources of divine salvation, the way they refuse any meaning that is not produced from within the symbolic sphere, returning us to our own devices, our own striving for meaning and authority, in the process. In this case the messianic retains the crucial organizing function of the symbolic; it makes meaning possible without having that meaning overwrite our lives with yet more mythology (it doesn't allow any one particular meaning to trump all the others).

Revisiting the Man from the Country

To briefly extend this analysis to another of Kafka's texts already considered, in "Before the Law," we can see that the Doorkeeper, rather than being a villain, might actually be the messiah as well. Although the man's fate of lingering at the door of law seems awful, it would have been far worse if the doorkeeper relented and let him into the door of law and exposed him to all of its secrets (although we are told that there are other, nastier, doorkeepers within the door of the law). If somehow he had finally gained access to the law, the man from the country would have been confirmed in all of his delusions about Halakah. There would have been no space for resistance, no mighty paw of haggadic uprising; the very distinction between law and its representation would have been erased. So in a way, the doorkeeper and the man from the country can be read as fellow conspirators collectively denying some great resolution and thereby keeping their conspiracy going against far greater and more irresistible powers.

In the meantime, they have established a *de facto* society, a society of two to be exact. What they chose to do with their time is irrelevant (at some point, the man from the country gets very well acquainted with the doorkeeper's fleas). What matters is that they are situated in a site of irresolution. Their community, by virtue of its explicit exclusion from the law, is somewhat left to its own devices, a position afforded by its members' mutual conspiracy. If the doorkeeper is the messiah, he goes unnoticed and unappreciated, even apparently the villain of the parable. He, like the messiah in *The Castle*, saves the world, but nobody notices (certainly not the man from the country). The communities that are revealed in his wake (usually) go similarly unrecognized, so fixated are we on the faux symbols, the Klamms, sovereigns, authors, and potentates that leave us truly bereft.

The Silence of the Sirens

If we think further about the relationship between these moments of messianic interruption and our own acts of conspiracy, we can begin to see that for Kafka, as for Benjamin, such events are simultaneous—possibly identical in some sense, even as they are mutually implicated. In an act of "divine violence," the messianic serves to destroy its own representation "which myth bastardized with law."⁵⁰ At the same moment, our duty is to conspire against our own time and intentions, to use Haggadah (or to go along with its use) as a "mighty paw" to raise against the false appearances

of Halakah. We can see that both gestures are the same: the exposure and decentering of false idols.⁵¹

For Benjamin (and I'd argue for Kafka as well), these gestures must be simultaneous to succeed. In keeping with the Jewish mystical tradition that the messiah is always here, Benjamin famously tells us, "Like every generation that preceded us, we have been endowed with a *weak* Messianic power."⁵² But this power is nothing, or rather provides nothing but an opportunity, if we don't act ourselves. Thus, to return to Kafka's stories, neither K. nor the man from the country is "redeemed" by the messianic gesture of self-voiding, or rather if they are, their redemption seems useless unless it somehow comes to their attention, becomes legible to them.

Here we come to the trickiest part of Kafka's notion of redemption because, as we have seen, K. cannot know that he has been redeemed—he *must* miss the messiah to avoid reasserting the very mythologies that the messiah has (potentially) voided. Given the unfinished and unresolved nature of *The Castle* (is K. redeemed? Does he know? How could we tell?) a consideration of a different writing, Kafka's short parable "The Silence of the Sirens" ("Das Schweigen der Sirenen"), may offer us some illumination about how to think further about K.'s intentionality, about his role in his own conspiracy (and, by extension, the role of any fellow conspirator as well). In "The Silence of the Sirens" (wherein, in a classic act of misrecognition of his own—whether deliberate or not—Kafka completely twists the story of Ulysses around to suit his purposes), we are told that Ulysses filled his ears with wax and chained himself to the mast in order to avoid the lure of the Sirens' song. In doing so he didn't know that "the Sirens have a still more fatal weapon than their song, namely their silence."⁵³ While his ears are blocked up, Ulysses imagines that he is escaping their songs; little does he know that they aren't making any noise at all.⁵⁴

Here we see a failure, an accidental conspiracy by a human agent. Yet, via his own confusion and misrecognition, Ulysses earns redemption even though he doesn't know what that redemption means or looks like (or how it came about). His conspiracy, his turn to wax and chains *does* work but to do so, it must be simultaneous with a crucial messianic function—the *aporia* of the Sirens' silence. Indeed, Kafka suggests that the Sirens are silent because of the spectacle of Ulysses' joy at his own scheme—a mutual case of misreading with happy results for Ulysses (Kafka begins this parable by stating, "Proof that inadequate, even childish measures, may serve to rescue one from peril").⁵⁵ Such misrecognition produces, in effect, the same dynamic we saw with Baudelaire's belief in novelty in the previous chapter. Baudelaire's misrecognition allows his own role in his

conspiracy with language to remain “hidden from [him],” even as it also permits him to expose the centralizing myths of commodity fetishism, if not for himself, then for us, the readers of his text.⁵⁶

And the same construction applies to *The Castle*. Due to his obsession with Klammer, K. encounters the messiah (he would never have been in that sleigh if he hadn’t been waiting for Klammer). By an act of grace, the same act of idolatry on K.’s part becomes transformed into a redemptive moment because the exact same gesture of missing God coincides with God’s act of becoming missed (or miss-able). This is how the two gestures are in fact one even as they are not legible in the same way.

By voiding itself, the messianic function allegorizes the signs of the divine (or perhaps more accurately in Kafka’s case, renders them into parables). The failure of the sign to mean anything becomes legible, albeit in ways K. misunderstands and only dimly perceives (without, however, annihilating the sign or K.’s attachment to it). In the face of such an exposure, the quest for meaning that drives us to idolatry is disrupted, potentially turning us from being stooges into acting as “coconspirators” with the divine.

The two acts in question, one of messianic intervention and the other of our own conspiracy, haunt and inform one another. If the messiah acted without the obscurity of our own obsessions (that is to say, if we saw it for “what it is”), we would be condemned to a perfect form of idolatry, a myth without antidote insofar as the messiah would be implicated in our belief and thus no longer able to “rescue” us. If we acted without the messiah’s act of self-voiding, we risk thinking, along with Ulysses and K., that our delusions are correct; that we *were* saved by wax and chains, or that Klammer really is going to save us. Such a delusion without redemption returns us to the very mythologies that both Kafka and Benjamin are trying to save us from. In either case, it is the balance and simultaneity of these gestures, the way they cast one another into doubt, that proves redemptive, a source of “hope” if anything is.

Failure and Redemption

In order to complete this discussion of the messianic function in Kafka’s work (and by extension, Benjamin’s as well), it may be useful to contrast my reading with that of another Kafka scholar. In her own musings on the question of Kafka’s failure and what it offers, Ewa Plonowska Ziarek makes an important argument about what Kafka is up to in his parables,

and I am largely in agreement with her. Yet I would here like to suggest that to leave out an explicit consideration of messianism (as I think she does to some extent) is also to leave out part of the central mechanism of Kafka's subversion and hence a key element of textual conspiracy.

In her analysis, Ziarek offers that reading Kafka's failure as a wholly negative event misses its radical nature. She too reads Kafka through the rubric of Benjamin's own work, writing:

Although the production of exemplary sense is undercut in Kafka's parables by their ostensible rhetoric of failure, Kafka's texts, as Walter Benjamin reminds us, do not merely dramatize the inaccessibility of truth but redefine the very function of rhetoric in terms of a paradoxical task, or an impossible obligation of transmission.⁵⁷

For Ziarek, Benjamin helps us to explain what Kafka's parables are actually doing—a kind of radical undermining of the very bases of meaning and authority. We are left, as Benjamin tells us, with a kind of pure transmissibility, a pure reduction to the sign, and in this, I am completely in agreement with her.

Ziarek helps us identify a pattern of productive failure in Kafka's work that links a great number of his works. She talks, for example, about his writings on the Tower of Babel, such as "The City Coat of Arms" ("Das Stadtwappen"). Here, a huge city is built in order to house all of the experts and builders who expect to build a "tower that will reach to heaven."⁵⁸ Of course such a thing is impossible, and so the tower never gets built. Ziarek notes that the city, which thrives despite the uselessness of its core mission, is "decentered, heterogeneous, built without any governing idea."⁵⁹ Furthermore,

Mirroring the predicament of the builders of the city, Kafka's own interpretation of the biblical text reflects the possibilities and risks of textual transmission. . . . When completion or supplementation of the previous text is indistinguishable from its destruction, then the process of transmissibility implied in Kafka's parables subverts the stability of transcendental ideas both in their own discourse and in the texts that serve them as antecedents.⁶⁰

This view is in keeping with what we have already encountered in *The Castle* (and *The Trial*) as well: a community that is busily forming itself in the expectation of some great organizing principle, some great delivery

that never arrives. But perhaps just as important, and not noted by Ziarek, is the very end of this parable:

All the legends and songs that came to birth in that city are filled with longing for a prophesied day when the city would be destroyed by five successive blows from a gigantic fist. It is for that reason too that the city has a closed fist on its coat of arms.⁶¹

The “longing” for such messianic redemption (in the form of a clear act of divine violence), for the ridding of all delusions that might be brought by such an act, does not mean that this event will actually occur. But such a longing does suggest that the residents of this city are already in some way released from the totalizing grip of their delusion. Their dream of divine violence serves messianically to destabilize their own conviction that they are already perfectly working out God’s plan. Such dreams potentially make the community they *do* have legible to these subjects, even in the face of the overarching beliefs that render the community peripheral even to itself.

As I see it, therefore, the idea of pure transmissibility, a Haggadah shorn of its requirement to represent Halakah, is only half of the equation. Without some kind of messianic self-voiding, some kind of anti-idolatrous intervention that does not merely reproduce another variant of phantasmagoria, the cities and communities that we build will simply fall into another form of mythmaking. The role of the messiah in this case is to trouble the delusions of the humans that live in expectation of its arrival—to turn their idolatrous rebellion into a redemptive and ongoing conspiracy with the messiah.

Conspiring by Design

Having laid out this argument about what could be called the accidental structure of our salvation, that is to say, our own misrecognition and failure as crucial elements in freeing us from the delusions of idolatry, it must be said that Kafka occasionally indicates what appears to be another version of conspiracy that comes a bit closer to the kind of open, conscious forms of resistance that one would expect to make for a properly “political” theory of conspiracy. After all, we expect our political actors to know what they are doing, to avoid stumbling on redemption by accident or by factors utterly beyond our control.⁶²

We see something of this element in Kafka's initial decision to make K. more aware of his conspiracy, a decision that he rescinded in later iterations of *The Castle*. As Mark Harman points out, in his rewriting of *The Castle*, Kafka "flattened his characters" and especially K.⁶³ The original hero has a "decisive deed ("entscheidenden Tat") to perform in the Castle. As Harman tells us, the original K. "is an aggressive and duplicitous character who openly admits his willingness to cheat and lie to gain what he wants."⁶⁴ Any hint of this mission is, however, eliminated in the "final" text (that is to say, the text that Max Brod actually published posthumously, and against Kafka's explicit wishes).⁶⁵ Thus, via his editing, Kafka has produced his subject's passivity. In rendering K. as a kind of confused, stumbling everyman, Kafka is de facto reducing his own agency in the text (Harmon also notes Kafka's deletion of references that made it obvious that K. was an autobiographical foil for Kafka himself).⁶⁶ In this way, Kafka makes space for the kind of messianic delivery that K. "experiences." As author, he abandons K. as an extension of himself and his own agenda; he allows K. to similarly be abandoned by the messiah in the text and left truly to his own devices.

We see indications of this more "conscious" style of conspiracy elsewhere as well, including in "The Silence of the Sirens" itself. Kafka ends that parable by mentioning a "codicil to the forgoing that has been handed down":

Ulysses, it is said, was so full of guile, was such a fox, that not even the goddess of fate could pierce his armor. Perhaps he had really noticed, although here the human understanding is beyond its depths, that the Sirens were silent, and opposed the afore-mentioned pretense to them and the gods merely as a sort of shield.⁶⁷

Although "beyond human understanding," this alternative view of Ulysses does more than gain redemption by accident. *This* conspiracy might just take on the question of "raising a mighty paw" against Halakah (in this case with the wax and chains, the symbols by which the sirens are "not heard") in a more open, acknowledged way.⁶⁸ In this rendition, the joke isn't on Ulysses but on the gods themselves.

Yet in this case it is not clear that we are really dealing with another form of conspiracy; rather, from our limited and compromised position, it becomes tempting to read (or depict) such a conspiracy along the lines of how we think politics and conspiracy ought to be promulgated. We see in effect the author of these texts, Kafka himself, occasionally following

the path of Ulysses, insofar as he attributes (at least some of the time) to his characters a fuller power over their own salvation (or doom) than his own writings would normally suggest were possible or desirable.

The fact that even an author as esoteric as Kafka seems to display this tendency suggests that it is difficult if not impossible from within our own perspective to perfectly portray a pure messianic event or to recognize the difference between a subject who has been redeemed by the messiah and one who has redeemed her- or himself (given that these are simultaneous gestures). Any language used to describe our own role in conspiracy will inevitably employ the vocabulary of agency and deliberate action, further muddying this distinction. Whether our actions in such circumstances are “accidental” or “on purpose” becomes a very loaded question.

Indeed, it may be that when he portrays a more “deliberate” style of conspiracy, Kafka is struggling with the temptation to project his own unreconstructed sense of agency onto the process he describes (his alterations of his own text while writing *The Castle* suggest the ways that he may have sought to combat his own interference).

Or, perhaps, in describing a deliberate form of plotting as he does, Kafka is simply gesturing toward the same kind of “progressive deepening of . . . intention” that Benjamin describes. He is trying to imagine or depict what an agency that is “not ours” might look like from our limited, compromised perspective. But his gesture must remain only that—a gesture; to suggest that we could actually emerge out of our compromised status with our intentionality scrubbed clean of idolatry, that we are capable of a “decisive deed,” is potentially to fall into the very sorts of ultimate phantasmagoria that Kafka’s text is set against.

Here we see that the notion of a self that is “not us” and that is fully and finally redeemed carries its own kind of danger. As we will see further in the following chapters, in the process of aligning ourselves with signs and symbols, we must resist a sense of moving toward final resolution lest we become an idol unto ourselves. The very term “progressive deepening” (admittedly Benjamin’s term, not Kafka’s) suggests a pathway rather than a final goal. Instead of seeking final resolution, the process must remain an ongoing method, or lodestone, by which we can continue to struggle against our own idolatry. The “us” that emerges in this process is not some free, self-actualized subjectivity but an ongoing work in progress (something we will discuss further in chapters 4 and 5). Such a self may look “deliberate” from our current perspective (where we are totally overwritten by the phantasmagoria), but it remains an artifact of our conspiracy and disappears when and if we cease conspiring.

The Coming of the Messiah

When Benjamin says of Kafka: "No other writer has obeyed the commandment 'Thou shalt not make unto thee a graven image' so faithfully," he is pointing to a way in which Kafka, perhaps even more than Benjamin, generally allows his intentionality to be decentered by the "intention of the sign." In this way Kafka not only describes but also models the method that Benjamin would apply more generally. Kafka's acts of authorial self-effacement function as and, to some extent, constitute the messianic act of self-voiding in his texts. In seeking to withdraw his conscious agency somewhat from the text, he makes room for other intentions, other voices to be heard.

In speaking of Kafka's messiah we need not be too mystical; this "messiah" is, after all, simply a character in or aspect of his text. As author, Kafka can never know (nor should we, his readers) the messianic function perfectly; here too, he can only gesture at it. Even Kafka does not have access to some kind of "outside" perspective that he is privy to; he too can only relate the messianic function through symbols and representations, through events and narratives of the text. Indeed we might say that Kafka's depiction of the messianic is perhaps itself a parable by which to gesture at the idea of human beings being "rescued" by the sign, a representation of the text as an ally and coconspirator.

Both Kafka as author and the messiah in his text do very little to transcend or disturb the ordinary operations of his novels or short stories. After all, for all his self-effacing, Kafka is still the author of his works, and his messiahs are so unobtrusive as to scarcely be noticeable as such. Yet what little that they do does not leave us unaffected. As readers we are "redeemed" by these acts of self-voiding (on both the author's and the messiah's part) insofar as by eliminating the promise of telling us the true meaning of the text, they throw us back onto our own devices. We come to the text anew without any hope for resolution, and in this way we become more available to "the intention of the sign." Kafka's messiah is the avatar of this textual intention, displacing and subverting our complicit intentionality (potentially even his own) in order to foster the habit of deferring to the text for our guidance.

In his own most direct reference to the messiah in "The Coming of the Messiah" ("Das Kommen des Messias") Kafka tells us that "The messiah will only come when he is no longer necessary; he will come only on the day after his arrival; he will come, not on the last day, but the very last."⁶⁹ We will never, indeed must never, catch the messiah at its function. To do

so would be to return us to the very delusion that the messiah's arrival and departure has voided in the first place. The value of our own conspiracy, even though we are hopelessly compromised, even though we are total failures, is to give us a way to understand what has become possible even while excluding and hiding the messianic function. Such a move allows us to misrecognize the messiah's actions (and, perhaps, the actions of the author as well) and hence remain redeemed; it potentially transforms our clumsy and collaborationist acts into conspiracies.

Perhaps the key point to grasp here in reading Kafka is the need to "recognize our misrecognition," that is, to remain open to the kinds of misrecognitions that we require in order to navigate the realm of representation. Rather than either seeking "the truth," or nihilistically giving up on representation altogether (in the end both gestures lead us to the same level of delusion), Kafka suggests that we can just possibly learn to recognize how valuable our failures and misrecognitions are, to recognize that our various alliances and relationships, while equally based on misrecognition, nevertheless constitute a ground for (perhaps the only ground for) a good life and a decent politics.

We can see in the gestures that Kafka makes—gestures toward our own (redeemed) agency, gestures toward a textual messiah, gestures toward justice and community—that he is in effect engaging in his own practice of recognized misrecognition. These gestures are not "true"; they come from no inside knowledge and do not produce a decisive end to idolatry. But the genius of Kafka's gestures is that they subvert rather than reinforce the phantasms that they engage with. His gestures are not meant to illuminate truth but rather his (and our) knowledge of its absence. In that absence, in the *aporias* such gestures render legible, we have a possibility of thinking and acting without the certainty of being overwritten by phantasms.

When we recognize our misrecognition, we remain bound by the signs and symbols of authority and power. Yet when the overwhelming presence of some central narrative figure is distorted or removed, we gain more access to our own politics, our own relationality that is produced in the wake of such figures. To say that such communities now become "legible" to us does not mean, once again, that we are now "in the know," but only that these alternative forms of politics and identity have entered into our conscious lexicon. To "recognize" our misrecognition means to learn to live with what passes for reality, to take advantage of what we see and encounter and to make the best home for ourselves that we can in this context. It means to learn how to see the world not for "what it is" but for how

it can best be inhabited and also to recognize the ways that we have already been so inhabiting it.

Even if we are reluctant citizens of these fragile and peripheral communities (reluctant because we never cease wanting to be members of the shining, salvational community that we are promised by our own mythologies), our membership in them affords us a political space that is not inherently overdetermined by idolatry and phantasmagoria. We may be hopeless (indeed, we must be hopeless), but in that space without hope, we can yet learn how to endure and perhaps even to thrive a little in these forgotten spaces.

In the next chapter, we will leave aside this vocabulary of messiahs and redemption and look at the conspiracy from a far more prosaic viewpoint. Turning to the writing and plays of Niccolò Machiavelli, we will look at the specific strategies that Machiavelli may be suggesting for how to engage in conspiracy not only “within” a text but without as well, in our actual lived world and in our encounters with great organizing systems of power and authority. By reading an author with such an explicit and engaged political vocabulary, we are seeking to form a constellation between Benjamin’s central method of reading, Kafka’s understanding of agency and messianism, and, finally, Machiavelli’s own explicitly political conspiratorial strategies as a way to bolster and expand our conception of how this conspiracy works.